Hegel

Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel was one of the great philosophers of German idealism and the last of the great system-builders. Since his death, no one has taken up the challenge of including all of reality and all of existence in one comprehensive system. Even if Hegel fails to give a completely comprehensive account of the human condition, he deserves credit for attempting what may be impossible.

Hegel seeks a coherent account of the external world of nature, the internal world of consciousness and experience, and the process by which consciousness develops in historical time. He takes the idealist tradition that runs from Greece to the Enlightenment, gives it a historical dimension and builds a system around the development of the human mind or psyche, or, as he would put it, *Geist*. His original training was in theology. For anyone who finds Hegel difficult to read, his early theological writings offer the most accessible point of entry.

When I was a graduate student, I struggled with the *Phenomenology*, the *Philosophy of Right* and other works by Hegel. I told a philosophy professor that I knew what the individual words meant in English and in German, but when I put them together into sentences of a hundred or a hundred and twenty words, I could no longer make out what I was being told. Was the problem with me or with Hegel? The professor suggested starting with the early theological writings, particularly for readers with a background in theology. They connect Hegel with a text one may already know, the Bible. Becoming familiar with his distinctive readings of it and with his characteristic intellectual moves makes his later work more accessible. Whether the mature philosophy is theological or anti-theological remains one of the hardest questions about how to read Hegel.

Accounts of Hegel routinely invoke thesis, antithesis and synthesis. That pattern occasionally appears in his writings, but it is not dominant. Triads are. Hegel typically divides a subject into three parts, then each of those into three more, and continues subdividing until he runs out of ink. One might fit these divisions into the Procrustean mould of thesis, antithesis and synthesis, and that may sometimes be a fair reading. Hegel himself, however, does not explicitly use it as a general model. His habitual division into threes is more important.

Like the other nineteenth-century German philosophers, Hegel stands in the shadow of Kant. The breakdown of the Kantian synthesis, particularly of Kant’s account of the *Ding an sich* or thing in itself, generated some of the most fruitful developments in early nineteenth-century German philosophy. It gave rise to German idealism, first in Fichte and Schelling and finally in Hegel. There are, fittingly, three of them.

The problem of consciousness is central to Kant. We cannot know things in themselves. We know only the external world of appearances, mediated by the a priori forms of cognition. These forms necessarily stand between us and the external world as it is in itself. Things in themselves are accessible to the mind of God, on this reading of Kant, but not to human understanding. We must experience the world as human individuals experience it. Instead of experiencing a lectern directly as a thing in itself, for example, I experience it through space, time, causality, number, being, negation and the other forms of cognition.

Fichte and Schelling turn this account against Kant. Being and negation, according to Kant, are a priori forms built into the human mind. These forms prevent direct and unmediated access to the thing in itself. If the thing in itself is unknowable, how can Kant ascribe being to it? How can we know that there is any such thing? Once Kant has limited the scope of possible human knowledge in this way, there can be no grounds within his system for asserting the existence of a thing in itself. The early idealists therefore propose to dispense with it.

This move generates an intractable problem. Consider the lectern again. I perceive it only through the a priori forms, and I have no independent grounds for believing that the content of the world is already out there and that I merely give it form. The relation between the forms of cognition and the thing in itself is that of form to content. The things in themselves, or the whole world taken as one great thing in itself, supply the content of experience. The a priori categories give it form. They act rather like a mental cookie cutter: we take the material and shape it by means of space, time, causality, number, being and negation.

Once we eliminate the thing in itself, however, what material is left to shape? If there is no content independent of the mind, then the mind must create both the forms of cognition and the material given form by them. This explains the transition from Kant to Fichte and Schelling. Kant is sometimes called an idealist, but his is more precisely a critical philosophy, one that defines the limits of metaphysics and of the human mind. It is not as explicitly committed to idealism as the philosophies of Fichte and Schelling.

By retaining the thing in itself, Kant allows for an external reality apart from us or from mind. Fichte and Schelling discard it. Hegel wrote one of his early works on the difference between their systems, and the problem he inherits is intrinsic to idealism: solipsism. It is one thing to say that our mind creates the form of consciousness. If it also creates the content, nothing remains outside us. We are alone in a kind of magical show made up of experiences of our own creation.

Perhaps even “we” is saying too much. On this view there may be only me. The people I see make noises and behave in certain ways, but as appearances they are no different from chairs and tables. Without things in themselves, I am creating them along with everything else. Abandoning the thing in itself thus seems to force a choice between giving up Kant’s project and collapsing into radical idealism. The problem resembles the one that arises in Descartes: how do we know the external world, and how do we know that there is one?

Fichte and Schelling formulate the difficulty without escaping it. They see that Kant cannot consistently ascribe being to the thing in itself, but without it we appear to be left with mind creating the form and content of consciousness and with nothing outside it. Hegel tries to find a way out of this predicament. Whether his solution succeeds is open to question, but it is an intriguing move.

Hegel accepts that the world is a product of mind and that there is no thing in itself. The decisive point is that the world is not the product of my own little mind. Both my individual mind and everything else are products of one great mind, a vast collective subject called *Geist*. This word, around which Hegel’s system turns, is particularly difficult to translate into English.

The usual English choices are “spirit” and “mind”, neither of which quite works. *Geist* suggests something inward, psychical and immaterial, something in a sense prior to material nature and to the external world. “Spirit” has a mystical and overtly religious resonance. That is not entirely inappropriate, but it makes *Geist* sound less concrete than Hegel intends. “Mind”, on the other hand, plainly misses some of the uses of the German term. J. B. Baillie called his translation the *Phenomenology of Mind* but varies his rendering between “mind”, “spirit” and other expressions according to the context.

Some English associations help to evoke the connotations. The first is “ghost”, which suggests the spiritual, psychical or non-material aspect. This gets us only so far. *Geist* is meant to be not merely real, unlike a ghost, but ultimate reality and permanent truth. Another association is “geyser”.

Think of the geysers in Yellowstone, which periodically send up jets of hot water. The regular and predictable upwelling of something subterranean gives a sense of the way *Geist* develops. There is an acorn, as it were, that generates the oak of reality. Something built into *Geist* drives it to rise and unfold. It has its own internal force and operates according to its own laws, so its emergence, like a geyser’s, is regular, predictable and intrinsic to it.

The third association, and perhaps the closest to Hegel’s use, is “gist”, as in the gist or essence of an argument. Taken together, “gist”, “geyser” and “ghost” suggest aspects that “spirit” and “mind” alone fail to convey. Heidegger’s *Dasein* poses a similar difficulty in English. There is no single English word that immediately conveys what *Geist* is, and that matters especially because it is the centre of Hegel’s system.

Accounting for consciousness in the absence of a thing in itself, and apparently of an external world, is what the *Phenomenology of Spirit* is about. It is Hegel’s answer to a Kantian problem: how can we make sense of the idea that mind creates everything? Once the thing in itself is gone, only mind remains to generate the form and the content of consciousness.

For Kant, the a priori forms are built into the psyche and do not change. For Hegel, the very categories of cognition develop over time. Consciousness can change and grow, and its growth is teleological. It has a starting point, finite consciousness, and an endpoint, infinite consciousness. This is the progress of *Geist* through history, and the development of consciousness is in fact the development of self-consciousness. *Geist* generates the whole world, so it is coming to know itself. Each individual consciousness is a small fragment of that whole.

The book is, in the first place, a phenomenology. To look ahead to Husserl, the idea is that appearance is reality. The world as we experience it is what it is. There is no thing in itself, no inaccessible second level. The lectern is what it appears to be. Human history and the development of the human psyche are the psyche itself unfolding. There is nothing underneath or apart from that process.

The world discloses itself rationally to us when we approach it rationally. If reality is *Geist*, and the content of *Geist* is rationality, then a world that changes over time can itself be a rational process. This is the sense of that apparently obscure and implausible proposition. The world is the development of mind, which means that mind unfolds in time. The *Phenomenology* records and interprets the coming-to-be of knowledge as it

appears and develops. It is a philosophy of history as well as a kind of speculative or philosophical psychology.

The *Phenomenology* is best read late rather than at the beginning of one's philosophical education. It is a wonderful book, but daunting without familiarity with the other texts to which it alludes. Hegel has an encyclopaedic mind and is fluent in almost every discipline. When he is wrong, he is grandly wrong. Few combine such intellectual gifts with such wide reading. The allusions he makes in passing, expecting readers to recognise them, are among the chief obstacles to understanding the book.

Hegel draws on the history of Western philosophy, art, religion and culture. He looks at the successive phases of that culture and asks what kind of spirit would hold a particular belief, for how long, why it would hold it and why it would give it up. Is the succession arbitrary and contingent, or is there something that unifies it? For Hegel, the history of philosophy is the coming of *Geist* to self-knowledge. It begins with the external world and its understanding of that world, then proceeds dialectically through contradictions and impasses.

These impasses are fruitful because they propel consciousness to its next level. Finite and limited self-understanding rises through contradiction to higher forms. Its *telos*, or purpose, is complete, uncontradictory and absolute self-consciousness. On a right-wing reading, this can be understood as the reconciliation of God and humanity. On a left-wing reading, it is the reconciliation of human beings with themselves.

Hegel describes the spiritual odyssey of the West. To the extent that ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny, he is also describing his own odyssey from a naïve, pre-philosophical outlook to the conviction that the history of Western thought leads to him and his writing desk. This conviction can be expressed in the image of his pen writing the thoughts of God. If *Geist* is becoming self-conscious, the advancing edge of time is the here and now, which for Hegel happens to be his own position. Philosophers of history tend to see the world as if it led up to them. Where else could it lead? That tendency towards omniscience is one difficulty built into the project.

The *Phenomenology* can be read as a *Bildungsroman*, a novel of development or maturation. It shows how the great collective subject, *Geist*, becomes what it necessarily had to be. An Aristotelian idea underlies this account: entelechy, or natural purpose. Acorns naturally tend to become oaks, and infants to become adults. *Geist* tends towards complete self-consciousness and omniscience. Since it generates the whole world, to be fully conscious of itself is to be conscious of everything it could know. It is essentially divine, the mind of God. In this desire for final knowledge and divine omniscience one can hear echoes of Hegel's early theological training. His prose is difficult, but the subtlety of many of these ideas makes the effort of reading worthwhile.

If reality is constituted by *Geist* and there is no thing in itself, the real is rational because *Geist* is rational. Rationality and freedom go together. Kant's *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* provides a familiar point of reference: to be free is to be rational and autonomous. The German tradition takes up a connection between freedom and rationality that reaches back to the Greeks. This conception also joins freedom and reason to teleology. It tells us why the world works as it does as well as how it works. It concerns purposes as well as events, and is ultimately normative. It lets us discern ends in the world around us.

The process by which a position encounters its opposite and gives rise to a third form that preserves what is true in the earlier positions is called “sublation” in English. The German is *Aufhebung*. The ordinary verb *aufheben* can mean to lift or pick something up, as when something falls on the floor. It can also mean to cancel or abolish, and to keep or preserve. Hegel draws on all these senses.

History proceeds through this kind of sublation. A stage of consciousness is thought through until its limits, flaws and contradictions become apparent. What is true in it is kept, its flaws are overcome and a new stage answers questions left by the earlier one. That new stage generates problems of its own, which in turn give rise to a further stage. This is what makes the process dialectical. *Geist* is talking to itself, since it is the whole of reality and there is nothing else to talk to. Contradictions are gradually worked out, the bounds of finite understanding are broken, and the process reaches its end in infinity, the absence of contradiction and a kind of Parmenidean unity.

The process starts with sense and perception. Hegel argues, in a way familiar to Kantians, that known objects presuppose knowing subjects and that the categories through which we know the world are objective, not merely subjective. This is only a beginning. We know other people as well as apparently external, inert matter, and we define our consciousness and identity in relation to them. Hegel develops this point in the dialectic of lordship and bondage, often called the master–slave dialectic, which has been particularly influential in Marxist readings. At the earliest stage of consciousness, some are willing to risk their lives to dominate others. What they want above all is recognition: they want others to acknowledge their power, more than they want their labour or obedience.

Identity is thus socially constituted, and the human desire for domination has paradoxical effects. The movement from perceiving the world to trying to dominate other people marks the beginning of history. It can be compared to the Fall in the Bible, the beginning of sin, and to the beginning of alienation in a Marxist reading. Some combatants kill their opponents. The victors lord it over those who submit because they are unwilling to stake their lives on the struggle. This pattern occurs throughout the world.

Here the cunning of history comes into play. The master does not become free by becoming a master. He makes himself dependent on the slave. The slave, by contrast, confronts nature and produces what both need. The master needs the slave more than the slave needs the master. The irony is that the master is the one who is really enslaved. Masters are never seen running away from their slaves. By confronting the resistance, or negativity, of nature, the slave develops practical skills and inner capacities and achieves as much liberation as is possible at that stage.

This reversal gives rise to another stage, the unhappy consciousness. It is the awareness that the freedom we wanted has not been achieved. The unhappy consciousness attempts to attain freedom through resignation and reliance on itself. It seeks independence from slaves, from other people and from the external world, trusting only what is within itself.

In the history of philosophy this turn inwards is Stoicism. Hegel’s reading is particularly striking when we consider the two great Stoics of the Roman world: Epictetus, who had been a slave, and Marcus Aurelius, an emperor and master. The allusions are elusive.

One needs to know quite a lot about the history of philosophy to recognise that Hegel is pointing to Aurelius and Epictetus.

The Romans soon discover that Stoicism is not a satisfactory solution either. We cannot rely entirely on ourselves without genuine and solid knowledge of the world. Marcus Aurelius is unsure whether there are gods or whether there is simply nature, atoms in the void. Many things perplex him, and he repeatedly tells himself to attend to his duty and not to worry. His need for reassurance shows how much he is worried. When Stoicism is pushed to its logical conclusion and that genuine knowledge does not materialise, the next phase is scepticism.

Hegel may have Lucian the Sceptic in mind here. He assumes the reader has already read enough to put these references together, which says something about the impressive achievements of German high culture in his time. Taken all the way, scepticism leads to despair. It can be seen as part of the inner disintegration of Rome, but as an element of the psyche it leads to the end of speaking and thinking. The project of philosophy has failed and human self-consciousness has reached a gulf it cannot bridge.

This sets the stage for Christianity, the religion of spirit. It is no accident that what supersedes Stoicism and Roman scepticism is a universal religion. In it, *Geist* and the universality of humanity are recognised for the first time, though not philosophically. For Hegel, religion anticipates philosophy in an early, pictorial form. Both refer to absolute spirit, to what is essential in *Geist*, but Christianity, like any religion, represents *Geist* in images. It is distinct from philosophy itself. Hegel's account of why Christianity succeeds Stoicism and scepticism is a striking one.

The book then breaks off and changes direction. Hegel was a profound idealist thinker, but the *Phenomenology* is poorly organised. He was finishing it as Napoleon advanced through Jena, in the year the Holy Roman Empire came to an end after roughly a thousand years. Hegel did not even know whether the manuscript would reach the publisher. He was sending it off with cannons firing, houses being destroyed and soldiers passing through. Some readers suspect a deep structure that makes the book well organised after all. Given the circumstances, what is remarkable is that he finished it at all.

From Christianity the discussion turns to objective spirit, which concerns society, its rules and its organisation rather than the individual. Like Kant, Hegel holds that there is no freedom without law. Freedom is not the uncertain and contingent freedom of Robinson Crusoe. To be free is to be autonomous, to give oneself a law. One must establish rules for oneself, impose them on oneself and obey them.

The family is an example of this and the first stage of objective spirit. The second is civil society, with a further set of laws that regulate our lives. The third and final stage is the state. This is why Hegel is often read as a worshipper of the state. The point here is that the state is the last stage of objective spirit and is necessary for the further development of human capacities, particularly self-knowledge.

Art, when viewed in relation to these changes in objective spirit, represents the tensions between them. In Sophocles' *Antigone*, the conflict between Antigone and Creon is the conflict between the gods of the family, the earliest stage of objective spirit, and the

laws of the state, its last stage. Such conflicts appear in the content of art as well as in political history. Among the moderns the conflict takes the form of a clash between the individual and society. In Goethe's *The Sorrows of Young Werther*, the individual comes to grief in his encounter with society. Think of Werther being made to leave the evening gathering at which he wishes to stay.

Art is also an element of absolute spirit. Subjective and objective spirit come together in what Hegel calls absolute spirit. In its domains human beings reach the highest levels of self-consciousness. As usual with Hegel, there are three: art, religion and philosophy. They can plausibly be described as the realms of the greatest achievements of the human mind, and it is hard to think of anything of greater consequence to us. Some of Hegel's divisions are Procrustean and some transitions require leaps, but the interpretation offers considerable insight.

Art, the first stage of absolute spirit, itself passes through three phases. First comes the symbolic phase, exemplified perhaps by early mimetic gestures such as cave painting. Next comes the classical phase, which begins with myths about the gods and ends in irony. The gods are reduced to human size.

Greek tragedy makes this development visible. In Aeschylus' *Oresteia* there is moral rigour and seriousness. That moral orientation begins to fade in Sophocles and is abandoned in Euripides. The characters of Euripides are neurotic. He uses the *deus ex machina* and does not take the gods seriously. The movement is from gods to heroes to ordinary human beings, all too human. Homer can be placed at an earlier phase, still symbolic and referring back to the gods. After Euripides come Aristophanes and the rise of comedy. Through Greek art we see our conception of ourselves gradually move from myth to recognisably human life.

Hegel then takes us in the opposite direction so that we may come to know ourselves as we really are. The final phase of art is Romantic art. Its importance lies in its assimilation of the Christian emphasis on the self and on the significance of the individual. Goethe's works offer an example. This is the next phase in the development of human self-consciousness. The stages are necessary: the important conception of the self represented in Romantic art could not have appeared before the earlier phases. It is like climbing the rungs of a ladder. Art as a whole is the first stage in the development of absolute spirit.

The second stage is religion. It gives a sensuous, pictorial representation of the form of the world. Jesus teaches in parables to give people a picture of virtue rather than to present a logically rigorous account of it. This makes the teaching accessible to people who do not spend all their time in a library, as Hegel did. This stage is a necessary precondition for a philosophical culture in which something like Hegel's *Phenomenology* can be written.

Religion is an early, pictorial representation of the genuine self-knowledge of *Geist*. It develops from early forms of nature worship to what Hegel regards as the highest religion, Christianity. In it *Geist* is made universal but still represented in pictures. The Golden Rule offers an analogy for the passage from pictorial religious understanding to a direct, non-pictorial grasp of *Geist*. In the Gospels, Jesus enjoins us to do to others as we would have them do to us. The teaching takes memorable forms in the Beatitudes and parables of the Gospels, and in the command to love one's neighbour as oneself.

This is an early, metaphorical and poetic way of expressing the idea. It is not unreasonable to call Kant's categorical imperative the Golden Rule dressed up in its logical Sunday best. The point is that their content can be understood as the same. The imperative asks us to act only on a maxim that we could will to become a universal law of nature. In this reading, it asks us to treat others as we would want to be treated, just as Jesus does. The difference is that Kant does not put it in a parable. He gives it an explicit logical and conceptual form.

The difference between religion and philosophy therefore concerns how we understand rather than what we understand. Religion apprehends its subject through pictures, symbols and metaphors. Philosophy grasps it directly, logically and rationally. It is the conceptual self-apprehension of *Geist*, and that is why it is the final stage in humanity's understanding of itself. This doctrine has many implications. One of the most consequential for the subsequent history of philosophy is how to interpret the ending of Hegel's book.

At the end of the *Phenomenology*, the coming of *Geist* to self-consciousness in philosophy is associated with what Hegel calls the Golgotha of absolute spirit. Golgotha is the place where Jesus is crucified, the point at which heaven and earth meet. The expression is ambiguous. That may be intentional, although Hegel's haste and his tendency to write very long sentences are reasons not to assume that all his ambiguities are deliberate. In any case, the book has been read in two diametrically opposed ways, and the ambiguity is central to its understanding of the world.

Does the Golgotha of absolute spirit mean the death of God or the death of absolute spirit? Or does it mark the end of the finitude of absolute spirit, so that spirit becomes infinite? In that case it is perfected rather than dead. Is this the vindication of religion or its abolition? The answer is unclear, and Hegel makes some puzzling statements.

The left-wing or Young Hegelian reading treats Hegel as an atheist. It stresses the *Phenomenology* rather than the *Logic* and the *Encyclopaedia*, retaining the dialectic and the emphasis on change. It makes particular use of Hegel's statement that God is dead. This formulation is already in Hegel, before Nietzsche. Perhaps Nietzsche never forgave him. Yet Hegel's use of it does not by itself make him an atheist. He also described himself as a Lutheran.

On the right-wing reading, the death of God can mean a passage from symbol to rational and conceptual understanding. We go beyond religion by sublating it, preserving its essence and giving it a more satisfactory logical form. In this sense Hegel can be called a Lutheran. The religious interpretation understands the end of history as the reconciliation of God and humanity, the joining of our finite minds to an infinite, perfect and uncontradictory mind.

On the atheistic reading, the death of God can be taken literally. What happens in history is the overcoming of the alienation introduced in the dialectic of lordship and bondage. The *Phenomenology* ends with the reconciliation of humanity with itself. It has been alienated since the first emergence of domination, *Herrschaft*, in that dialectic.

Our understanding has always been partial, incomplete and finite. Its end is an infinite, final and complete understanding of ourselves, since there is nothing else to understand. If this is seen as the reconciliation of God and humanity, it is logically

analogous to the *Book of Revelation*, the end of the world. If it is understood in strictly atheistic and this-worldly terms, it is not a logical apocalypse but the point at which human beings finally become what they are. We are no longer the fragmented and disjointed horror that human history has shown us to be. It is not clear which of these readings is right.

Both readings are persuasive and important. I am inclined to think that Hegel was a religious believer and a Lutheran, and that he intended a kind of logical apocalypse in which God and humanity are reconciled. That is probably closer to his intentions, to the extent that they can be discerned. It has not, however, been the most fruitful reading. Misreadings can be useful and thoughtful, and the left-wing reading of Hegel as an atheist has been extraordinarily fruitful.

For Marx, the dialectic of lordship and bondage is especially important. It supplies an origin for domination, hierarchy and alienation. He can then read the reconciliation and abolition of alienation as the *telos* of history, the global proletarian revolution. That reading makes a certain sense. In the end, we cannot settle once and for all whether the self-understanding and self-knowledge of *Geist* are theistic or atheistic. As Wilhelm Dilthey is said to have remarked at the end of the nineteenth century, the generation that could read Hegel is dead.